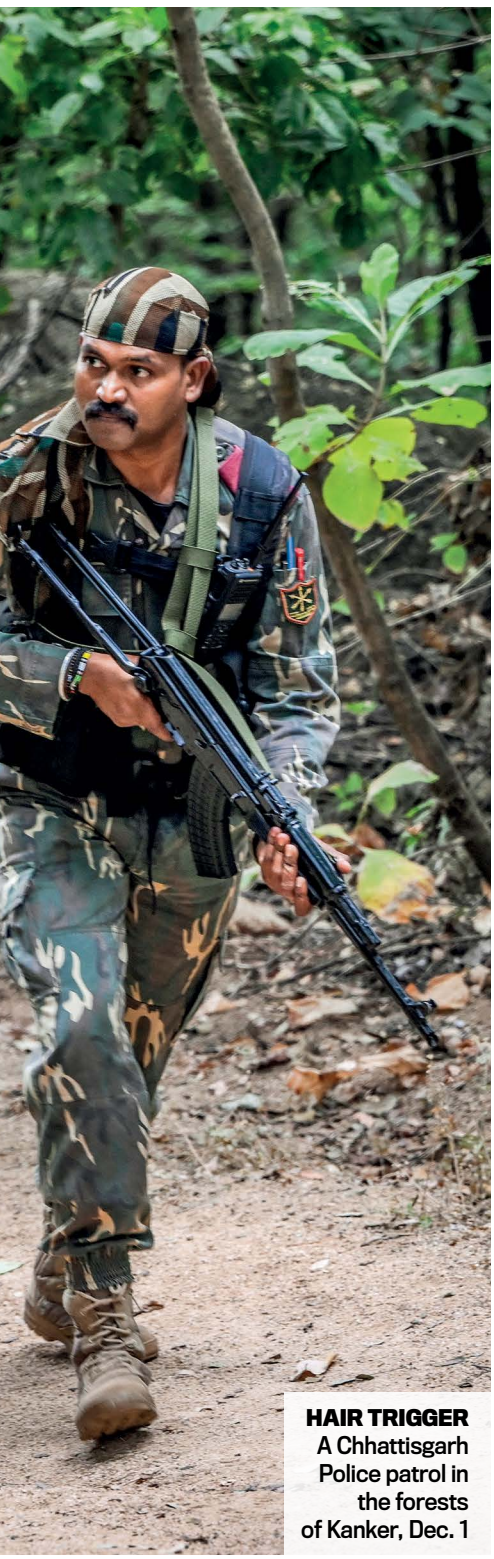
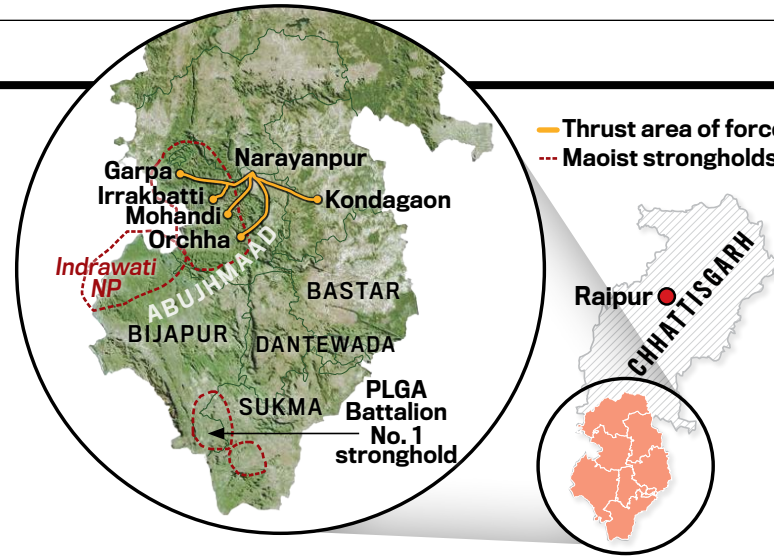
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HAIR TRIGGER A Chhattisgarh Police patrol in the forests of Kanker, Dec. 1



In Ground Zero Bastar, the war against Maoists registers big successes in 2024, with blanket presence, tech-enabled ops and a no-holds-barred strategy

By RAHUL NORONHA in Bastar

Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

It had been a lazy overcast afternoon in Dantewada in Bastar division, south Chhattisgarh, when suddenly the police lines, home to the District Reserve Guard (DRG), buzzes with activity. The local commander asks the troops—formations that have both boys and girls, and which are increasingly called the "tip of the spear" owing to their successes in the fight against Maoism—to get ready for a briefing. And so they do, gathering together their checked weapons, issued ammunition and hurriedly packing rucksacks with ready-to-eat rations, first-aid kits and spare clothes—not to mention body bags.

Thirty-six hours ago, an agency monitoring phone calls in remote areas had traced one made from atop a forested hill in south Bastar, an unlikely place for a civilian caller. The information was passed on to top police officers in Bastar. Call analysis, corroborated by ground intelligence and visuals from UAVs (unmanned aerial vehicles), suggested that there could be a Maoist camp in the area. The DRG commander explains that the site is around 100 km away, and the last 20 of the passage would be on foot in a jungle at night. There would be other elements in the strike party—the Chhattisgarh police's Special Task Force (STF) and the CRPF—all requisitioned by the district superintendent of police (SP) for the operation. The force loads up in SUVs and motorbikes while it gets dark. The hunt begins.

It's been a 'busy' 11 months for the forces this past year in Bastar division. As many as 207 Maoists have been killed between December 2023 and November 22, 2024—an unprecedented number considering only 20 had been brought down in all of 2023. Clearly, the forces seem to be working with the ministry of home affairs (MHA) deadline in mind—March 2026—to bring the decades-old war with left-wing extremism to a close. There have been 13 major operations in this period, with success too coming in big chunks. On October 4, for instance, 31 alleged Maoists died in a firefight in the forests bordering the Narayanpur and Dantewada districts, the highest in a single operation in the history of the insurgency in Chhattisgarh. (As an aside, the forces have raked in Rs 8.24 crore in reward money for their efforts.)